Ambedkar, who both quit to found their own political parties. In Parliament, criticism of foreign policy was often voiced by Opposition leaders like J.B. Kripalani, Ram Manohar Lohia, Deendayal Upadhyaya and Minoo Masani. But there were differences within Nehru's government as well, most notably on China, as ties with that country worsened. Current generations would perhaps be surprised at the salience of foreign-policy issues in driving domestic politics, both within the ruling Congress party as well as in the founding of alternatives.

One reason to go back in history is precisely because differing political viewpoints gained ground to the point of one of them (the BJP) eventually coming to power. Another is that the very issues of debate then are still the focus of challenges and opportunities now. Whether we could have created different outcomes is, therefore, not an entirely academic issue. But as Nehruvian beliefs used to be projected as a norm and others as deviations, these contestations are surely worth recognizing.

The conviction that Third World-centred solidarity would be a force strong enough to overcome any contradiction between newly emerging governments would be quixotic at best of times. But when actually practiced by a serving PM vis-à-vis an immediate neighbour, it became downright dangerous. This led to downplaying signals and actions in the 1950s that had implications for our security and well-being. We expended political capital espousing the cause of a neighbour who finally turned on us. And, at times, we even deluded ourselves that we had influence over their thinking!

To evaluate such policies, it is worthwhile to reflect on the basis for this supposed solidarity. At its heart was the conviction that there were sentiments and forces stronger than nationalism and powerful enough to overcome cultural identities. Those who hold such views tend to believe that others do so as well, especially if they belong to a similar school of thinking. It was this display of false internationalism that worried Nehru's peer group and led them to voice their concerns. The critique came with considerable variation in intensity, arguments and even the issues. Because they did not necessarily prevail at that point of time does not make their viewpoint irrelevant, especially if subsequent events demonstrated validity.

The standing of those asserting competing points of view is also material. Many of them were truly stalwarts of the independence struggle and some distinguished themselves in the Constitution-making process as